Alma E. Berowa

Contents

1 Dr. Alma Elape Berowa: *From Scholar of Psychology to Steward of a University System in Times of Crisis*
- 1.1 Introduction: A Life Shaped by Place and Purpose
- 1.2 Early Life: Foundations of Excellence in Gigaquit
- 1.3 Education: The Making of a Social Psychologist
- 1.4 Academic Career: Rising Through the Ranks
- 1.5 Leadership: From Department to System
- 1.6 Crisis Leadership: The Marawi Siege
- 1.7 Scholarship and Advocacy: Gender, Peace, and Society
- 1.8 Gender and Institutional Reform
- 1.9 Global Engagement and Academic Exchange
- 1.10 Personal Life and Values
- 1.11 A Legacy of Continuity and Care

Dr. Alma Elape Berowa: *From Scholar of Psychology to Steward of a University System in Times of Crisis*

Introduction: A Life Shaped by Place and Purpose

In Philippine higher education, attention often centers on institutions in Metro Manila, where resources and policy converge. However, in Mindanao, a different kind of leadership has quietly emerged—one built on endurance, cultural understanding, and crisis navigation.

Dr. Alma Elape Berowa exemplifies this leadership. Her career spans over four decades within the Mindanao State University (https://www.msumain.edu.ph/) (MSU) System, where she progressed from a young instructor in 1980 to the longest-serving Vice President for Academic Affairs, a role she held from 2011 until her retirement in 2025[1]. Her journey is intertwined with MSU's mission to bridge cultures, educate marginalized communities, and provide stability in a diverse and conflict-prone region.

Understanding Dr. Berowa means recognizing how academic leadership can transcend classrooms and administrative roles, becoming a service that directly addresses societal realities.

Early Life: Foundations of Excellence in Gigaquit

Dr. Berowa was born on September 16, 1960, in Gigaquit, Surigao del Norte. Her upbringing in the Caraga region shaped her early experiences and ambitions. Even as a child, she demonstrated academic discipline, graduating as salutatorian in elementary school and valedictorian in high school.

These achievements reflected her commitment and focus. In a provincial setting with limited opportunities, academic distinction required intelligence, persistence, and clarity of purpose.

Her transition to Mindanao State University marked a turning point. MSU, established to integrate the country's diverse cultural communities, became the institutional home where her intellectual and professional identity took shape.

Education: The Making of a Social Psychologist

Dr. Berowa entered MSU as a full scholar and completed her Bachelor of Arts in Psychology, graduating cum laude in 1980. Her undergraduate training, which included a minor in sociology, provided her with an interdisciplinary perspective that became central to her work. Rather than viewing human behavior in isolation, she approached it as something deeply embedded in social structures, cultural practices, and lived experiences.

She pursued graduate studies in education, beginning at the University of the Philippines (https://up.edu.ph) Diliman before completing her Master of Arts in Education, major in Guidance and Counseling, at MSU. This combination of psychology and education reflected a dual commitment: understanding human behavior and applying that understanding in institutional and community contexts.

Her academic journey culminated with a Doctor of Philosophy in Psychology, major in Social Psychology, from Ateneo de Manila University between 1990 and 1996. This period of advanced study deepened her engagement with questions of identity, conflict, and social interaction—issues that would later become central to her research and leadership, especially within the context of Mindanao.

Her education was a deliberate shaping of a scholar whose work would intersect with pressing social issues in the region.

Academic Career: Rising Through the Ranks

Dr. Berowa began her academic career in 1980 as an Instructor I in the Department of Psychology at MSU. Over four decades, she advanced through the academic ranks, becoming Full Professor VI in 2000 and attaining the distinction of University Professor in 2022.

Her rise was cumulative, built on years of teaching, research, and service. Her long tenure allowed her to develop familiarity with the institution's culture and challenges. She was shaped by the system and, in turn, shaped it.

Dr. Alma Elape Berowa



Personal Information	
Born	September 16, 1960
Birthplace	Gigaquit, Surigao del Norte (CARAGA Region)
Home Address	038 4th Street, MSU Campus, Marawi City
Spouse	Pasayod P. Berowa (رَحِمَهُ الله) (Retired HRMO III, PhilHealth BARMM; Deceased)
Children	• Ian Nasser Berowa (Associate Professor V, MSU; PhD candidate) • Ivan Yasser Berowa (University Researcher II, MSU) • Ivy Sarah Mae Berowa (Professor VI, MSU; Registered Social Worker, DPA) • Pasayod Berowa, Jr. (MSU Staff; Registered Nurse) • Ivar Shanollah Berowa (Major, Philippine Army)
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Academic Position	
Title	University Professor (Retired)

Her work extended beyond the classroom. She contributed to curriculum development, mentored students and junior faculty, and participated in academic governance. Her role expanded from teacher to steward of the university's intellectual direction.

Position	Vice President for Academic Affairs, MSU System
Tenure	2011 to 2025

Leadership: From Department to System

Before ascending to system-wide leadership, Dr. Berowa held several key administrative positions within MSU-Marawi, including Department Chair of Psychology, Guidance Coordinator, College Secretary, Assistant Dean, and Dean of the College of Social Sciences and Humanities. Each role enhanced her understanding of academic institutions, from departmental operations to college administration.

When she became Vice President for Academic Affairs in 2011, she brought decades of institutional experience. Her tenure, lasting until 2025, is the longest in the history of the MSU System. During this time, she oversaw critical aspects of academic governance, including curriculum development, faculty promotion, admissions, scholarship programs, and accreditation processes.

Her leadership style emphasized continuity and system-building. Rather than pursuing short-term reforms, she focused on institutionalizing enduring processes. She chaired key bodies, including the University System Curriculum Committee, the Academic Promotion Panel, and the Quality Assurance Board, all vital for maintaining and improving academic standards.

The results of her efforts became evident in the university's performance. Under her guidance, MSU achieved top national rankings in accredited programs, particularly in 2023 and 2024. These achievements reflect both administrative efficiency and a commitment to academic excellence.

Crisis Leadership: The Marawi Siege

If her administrative work demonstrated her capacity for system-building, the events of 2017 revealed her leadership under pressure.

When armed conflict erupted in Marawi City on May 23, 2017, the MSU campus became the center of a humanitarian crisis. Many fled for safety, but Dr. Berowa chose to remain on campus. From the first day of the siege until the city's liberation in October, she stayed alongside a small group of university officials.

During this period, her responsibilities extended far beyond academic administration. She helped organize the evacuation of vulnerable faculty and students, assisted in the distribution of food and essential supplies to those remaining on campus and in surrounding communities, and drew on her training as a psychologist to lead psychosocial interventions for individuals coping with trauma and displacement.

One of the most symbolic moments was the "Bakwit Graduation" held in Iligan City, allowing displaced students to complete an important milestone in their lives. This act underscored a central principle of her leadership: education must continue, even amid disruption.

Her presence during the siege transformed her role. She became not just an academic administrator, but a crisis leader, humanitarian worker, and a source of stability for a community in turmoil.

Scholarship and Advocacy: Gender, Peace, and Society

Parallel to her administrative work, Dr. Berowa actively engaged in research and advocacy focused on reproductive health, gender dynamics, and the experiences of conflict-affected communities.

Her publications explored the reproductive health perspectives of Maranao youth, the experiences of women in conflict settings, and the ethical challenges of researching marginalized communities. These works connect academic inquiry with real-world concerns.

She was a founding member of the Al-Mujadilah Development Foundation, focusing on women's rights and development in Muslim communities, and worked with organizations like BIRTHDEV, which supports women and children affected by conflict and disasters.

Through these efforts, she bridged the gap between research and practice, ensuring her work had tangible impact beyond academic publications.

Gender and Institutional Reform

As Chair of Gender and Development from 2015 to 2023, Dr. Berowa integrated gender perspectives into university policies and programs. She mainstreamed gender sensitivity in the curriculum and promoted awareness of issues like violence against women and reproductive health.

Her efforts aligned with national and international frameworks on gender equality, positioning MSU as a responsive institution. She also participated in policy discussions at the national level through her involvement with the Commission on Higher Education and other bodies.

Global Engagement and Academic Exchange

Dr. Berowa's work extended internationally through conferences, research collaborations, and academic exchanges. She participated in Erasmus exchange programs in Portugal and Türkiye.

These experiences enriched the MSU System's internationalization and allowed her to share the challenges of Mindanao with a broader audience.

Personal Life and Values

Behind her professional accomplishments lies a life shaped by personal commitments. She is a mother of five, many of whom have pursued careers in academia and public service. Her role as a parent and her experiences as a widow reflect a balance between personal resilience and public duty.

Her values—service, empathy, and commitment to community—are evident in both her professional and personal life.

A Legacy of Continuity and Care

Dr. Alma Elape Berowa's career exemplifies the achievements of academic leadership grounded in intellectual rigor and human concern. Her work strengthened institutional systems, advanced scholarship, and ensured educational continuity during a challenging period in MSU's history.

Her legacy is defined not just by her positions, but by her impact on students, colleagues, and the broader community. In a region often marked by challenges, she showed that leadership rooted in knowledge, compassion, and resilience can create lasting change.

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